



SOURCES & MONITORS

How rays are born, and how they're recorded

A closer look at source and monitor components in McStas & McXtrace

McStas — neutrons

McXtrace — X-rays



Peter Willendrup · DTU Physics

PaNRAID School · supported by PEPR DIADEM



What we'll cover

Building on the Common Introduction — now with a closer look at two component families every instrument needs.

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What a source does

Setting the ray state at the start of the beamline

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Anatomy of a simple source

Position, direction, and spectrum

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Solid angle, ncount, and statistical weight

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mcdoc & mxdoc, and how to read a component's parameters

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A shared monitor library

1D, 2D and nD monitors — and how they compute statistics



What a source component does

- A source generates rays — in McStas terms, it sets the ray state to something representative of the source being modelled.
- In practice: draw values for the ray's state vector from chosen distributions — not from a single fixed value.
- Example: rays of uniformly distributed wavelength, emerging from a circular aperture, aimed at a region of interest.
- Every other component downstream only ever sees a ray in this state — it doesn't know or care how the source produced it.

Recap — the ray state vector

McStas · neutron ray

$$\{ x, y, z, \quad vx, vy, vz, \quad t, \quad sx, sy, sz, \quad p \}$$

position · velocity · time · spin · weight

McXtrace · photon ray

$$\{ x, y, z, \quad kx, ky, kz, \quad Ex, Ey, Ez, \quad \varphi, \quad t, \quad p \}$$

position · wave vector · polarisation · phase · time · weight



Finding the docs

Every component's parameters, defaults and physics are documented — and the two codes use the same pattern to reach them.

You want...	McStas	McXtrace
Overview documentation page	<code>mcdoc</code> (or "Docs" in mcgui)	<code>mxdoc</code> (or "Docs" in mxgui)
The full PDF component manual	<code>mcdoc -c</code>	<code>mxdoc -c</code>
Docs for one specific component	<code>mcdoc <component_name></code>	<code>mxdoc <component_name></code>

Watch out: online copies of the manuals exist (mcstas.org / mcxtrace.org) but may not match your installed version exactly — the local `mcdoc` / `mxdoc` is always authoritative.



Anatomy of a simple source

Three questions every source answers — identically in shape, whichever code you're in.

1 Where?

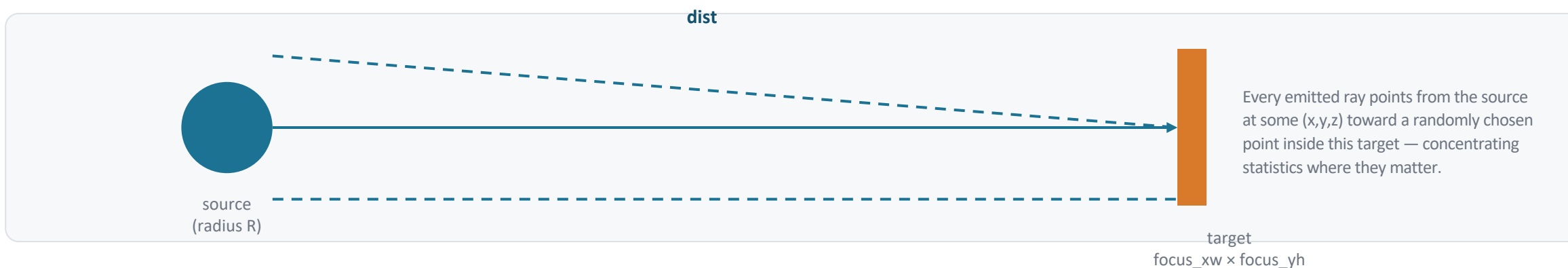
Pick a start point on the source surface — e.g. uniform on a disc of radius R .

2 Which way?

Aim toward a region of interest: a target of size $\text{focus_xw} \times \text{focus_yh}$ at distance dist .

3 What spectrum?

Assign a wavelength / energy from a chosen distribution — uniform, Gaussian, Maxwellian...





A minimal source, in both codes

```
COMPONENT src = Source_simple(  
    radius=0.05, lambda0=2.5, dlambda=1.5,  
    focus_xw=0.1, focus_yh=0.1, dist=5)  
AT (0,0,0) RELATIVE origin
```

McStas · Source_simple

```
COMPONENT src = Source_flat(  
    radius=0.05, lambda0=2.5, dlambda=1.5,  
    focus_xw=0.1, focus_yh=0.1, dist=5)  
AT (0,0,0) RELATIVE origin
```

McXtrace · Source_flat

Same parameter names, same units: radius, lambda0/dlambda, focus_xw, focus_yh and dist mean the same thing in both instrument files — only the wavelength range and physical scale differ between neutrons and X-rays.



Two source landscapes

This is where the two libraries look most different — shaped by very different facilities.

McStas · neutron sources

MATHEMATICAL

`Source_simple, Source_div`

REACTOR / CONTINUOUS

`Source_Maxwell_3, Source_gen`

PULSED (SPALLATION)

`ESS_butterfly, Moderator, SNS_source, ISIS_moderator`

PARTICLE-LIST I/O

`MCPL_input / MCPL_output`

McXtrace · X-ray sources

MATHEMATICAL

`Source_flat, Source_div, Source_pt`

ACCELERATOR INSERTION DEVICES

`Bending_magnet, Wiggler, Undulator`

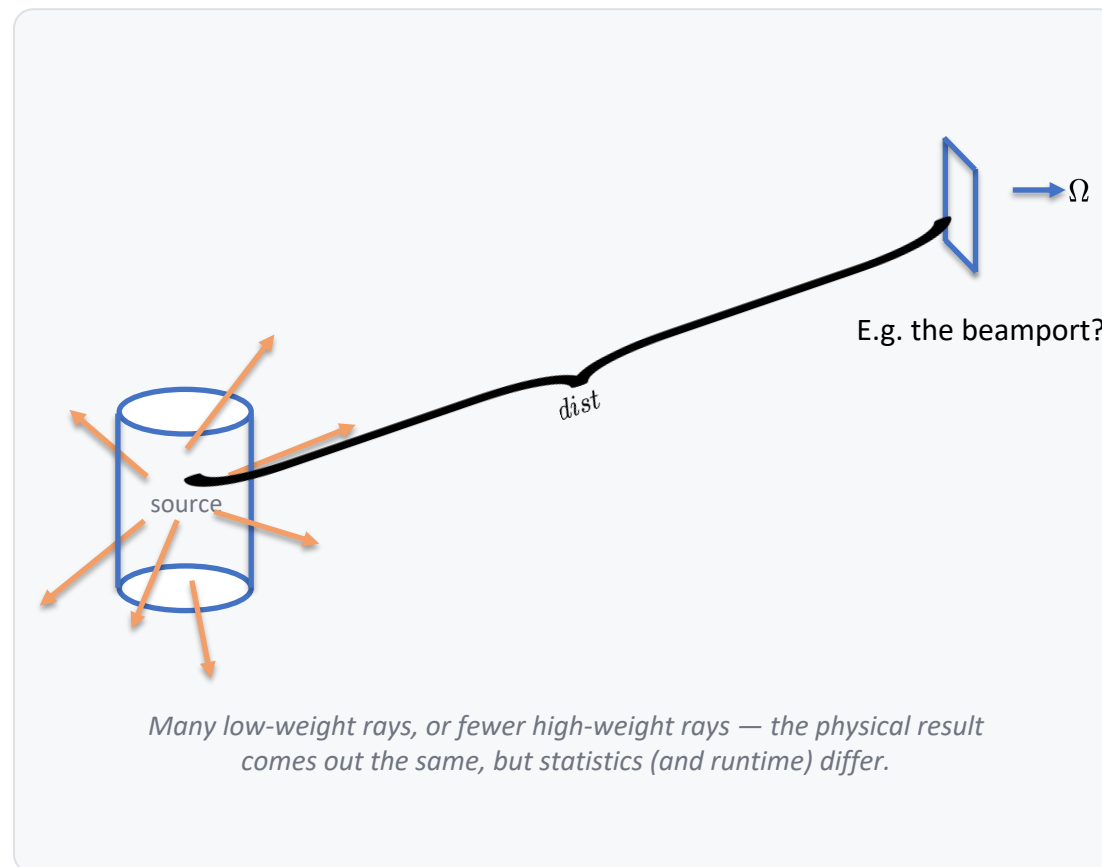
PARTICLE-LIST I/O

`MCPL_input / MCPL_output`

Neutron sources mirror facility diversity (reactor vs. spallation); X-ray sources mirror accelerator physics (magnet type). Both share simple analytic sources and the same MCPL format.

Solid angle, ncount, and ray weight

- Most neutron- and some X-ray sources emit into the full 4π steradian — but a simulation only needs the solid angle Ω subtended by the beamline's first aperture.
- The emission integrated over Ω , wavelength and time gives a physical intensity (rays / second).
- That intensity is partitioned over a finite number of simulated rays: ncount (default 1e6, set with -n / --ncount).
- Each ray carries a statistical weight p, chosen so the sum of weights over all rays reproduces the physical intensity.





MCPL: coupling simulations together

MCPL_output writes the full ray state to a portable, code-agnostic file at any point in an instrument.

MCPL_input reads those rays back in as a source — in the same code, or a different one entirely (McStas $\leftrightarrow$ McXtrace $\leftrightarrow$ MCNP $\leftrightarrow$ Geant4...).

```
COMPONENT vout = MCPL_output(filename="v.mcpl", doubleprec=1, polarisationuse=1)
AT (Xout,Yout,Zout) RELATIVE PREVIOUS

COMPONENT vin = MCPL_input(filename="v.mcpl", polarisationuse=1)
AT (Xin,Yin,Zin) RELATIVE PREVIOUS
```

Coordinates travel with the rays: MCPL stores an implicit translation/rotation, so a ray written out at one orientation is placed correctly when read into an instrument with a different local frame.



Pulsed neutron sources

Reactors run continuously; spallation sources are pulsed. McStas offers a spectrum of ways to model that.

The simplest trick

Use a continuous source and force an infinitely short pulse: $t = 0$ or define a short pulse via a `rand01()` for every ray within an **EXTEND** block — or use a chopper to carve pulses out of a continuous beam.

```
COMPONENT src = Source_simple(...)
AT (0,0,0) RELATIVE origin
EXTEND %{
    t = 10e-3*rand01(); // 1 ms square pulse
%}
```

Dedicated pulsed-source components

Moderator flat pulsed source, uniform energy spectrum, energy-dependent pulse shape

ESS_butterfly ESS's characteristic “butterfly” moderator brightness model

SNS_source / SNS_source_analytic samples MCNP target+moderator tallies (or fast Padé fits); also used for J-PARC, CSNS

ViewModISIS / ISIS_moderator samples tallies supplied per beamport at ISIS



Monitors vs. detectors, in general

Both codes draw exactly the same line — and let you program either behaviour when you need to.

Monitors

- An intensity probe of the beam
- Should be transparent to rays — efficiency $\ll 1\%$ (neutrons) / low efficiency (X-rays)
- Doesn't meaningfully perturb what happens downstream

Detectors

- Should detect (almost) every ray — efficiency as high as possible
- McStas models a real He3 tube via PSD_Detector
- Otherwise: both codes let a monitor be given any efficiency/transparency you specify

Same philosophy in both codes: “we refer to both indistinguishably as monitors” — the component is the same, only the parameters you give it change its role.

Simulation of 'real' detection-physics is an exception: “we leave that to expert-codes such as Geant4” — measurement is by default “magic / for free”



Adding monitors to a beamline

Swap the source component and the rest reads identically in McStas or McXtrace.

```
COMPONENT origin = Progress_bar()    AT (0,0,0) ABSOLUTE

COMPONENT src = Source_simple(radius=0.05, lambda0=2.5, dlambda=1.5,
                               focus_xw=0.1, focus_yh=0.1, dist=5)
AT (0,0,0) RELATIVE origin

COMPONENT psd = PSD_monitor(xwidth=0.2, yheight=0.2, filename="psd.dat")
AT (0,0,5) RELATIVE src

COMPONENT lm = L_monitor(xwidth=0.2, yheight=0.2, filename="lm.dat", Lmin=0, Lmax=8)
AT (0,0,5.01) RELATIVE src
```

In McXtrace: replace `Source_simple` with `Source_flat` — `PSD_monitor` and `L_monitor` are called exactly the same way.



A shared monitor library

Most monitors exist under the same name and parameter conventions in both codes.

1D

`L_monitor`

`TOF_monitor`

`Hdiv_monitor`

`E_monitor`

`MeanPolLambda *`

2D

`PSD_monitor`

`PSD_monitor_4PI`

`Divergence_monitor`

`DivPos_monitor`

`PolLambda_monitor *`

nD

`Monitor_nD`

— records almost

any requested

quantity, any

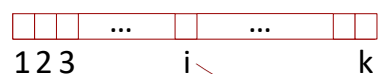
shape

** a small number of monitors are probe-specific — polarisation monitors exist for neutrons, not X-rays. Look up the full, current list with `mcdoc monitor` / `mxdoc monitor`.*



How a monitor computes its statistics

- Every bin (pixel) accumulates a running sum of ray weight as the simulation proceeds — not a per-ray record.
- At the end of the run, each bin reports three numbers: intensity I , its estimated RMS error E , and an effective event count N .
- I is the weighted sum of rays landing in that bin; E follows from the sum of squared weights — the Monte Carlo estimate of statistical uncertainty.
- The same estimator runs underneath every monitor, in both codes — from a single `L_monitor` to the full `Monitor_nD`.



$$I = \sum_N p_j$$

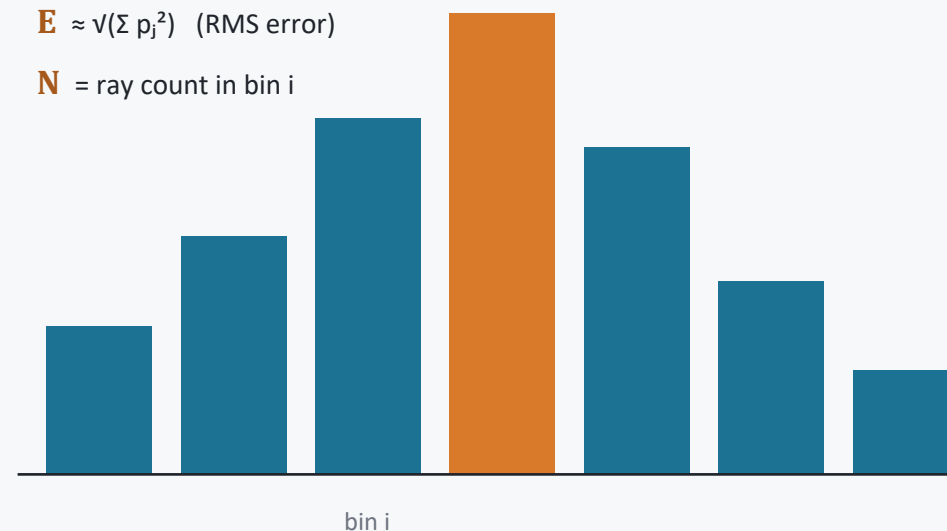
In bin i , N events each carrying a fractional intensity p_j so that

$I(\lambda)$: intensity per bin

$I = \sum p_j$ (summed weight)

$E \approx \sqrt{\sum p_j^2}$ (RMS error)

N = ray count in bin i





Monitor_nD: the swiss-army-knife

A general 0D / 1D / 2D recorder — almost any shape, recording almost any requested quantity — same options grammar in both codes.

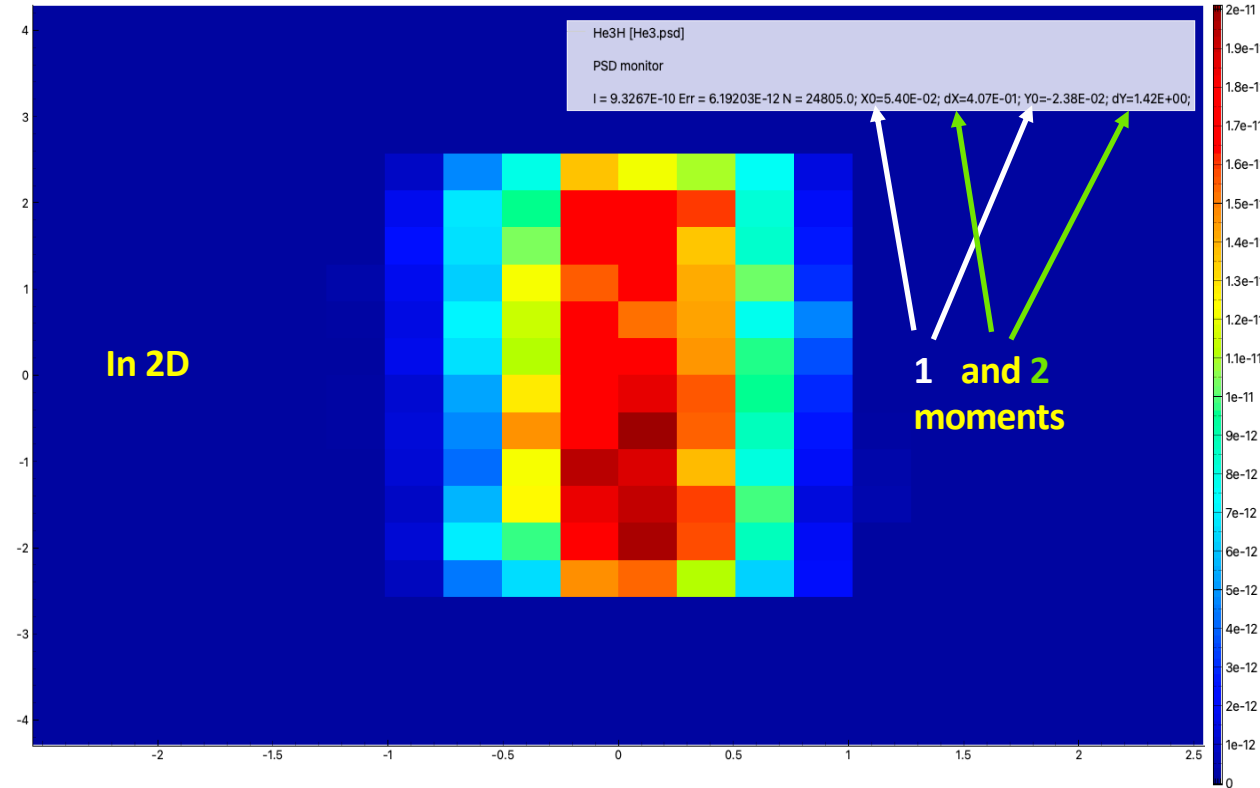
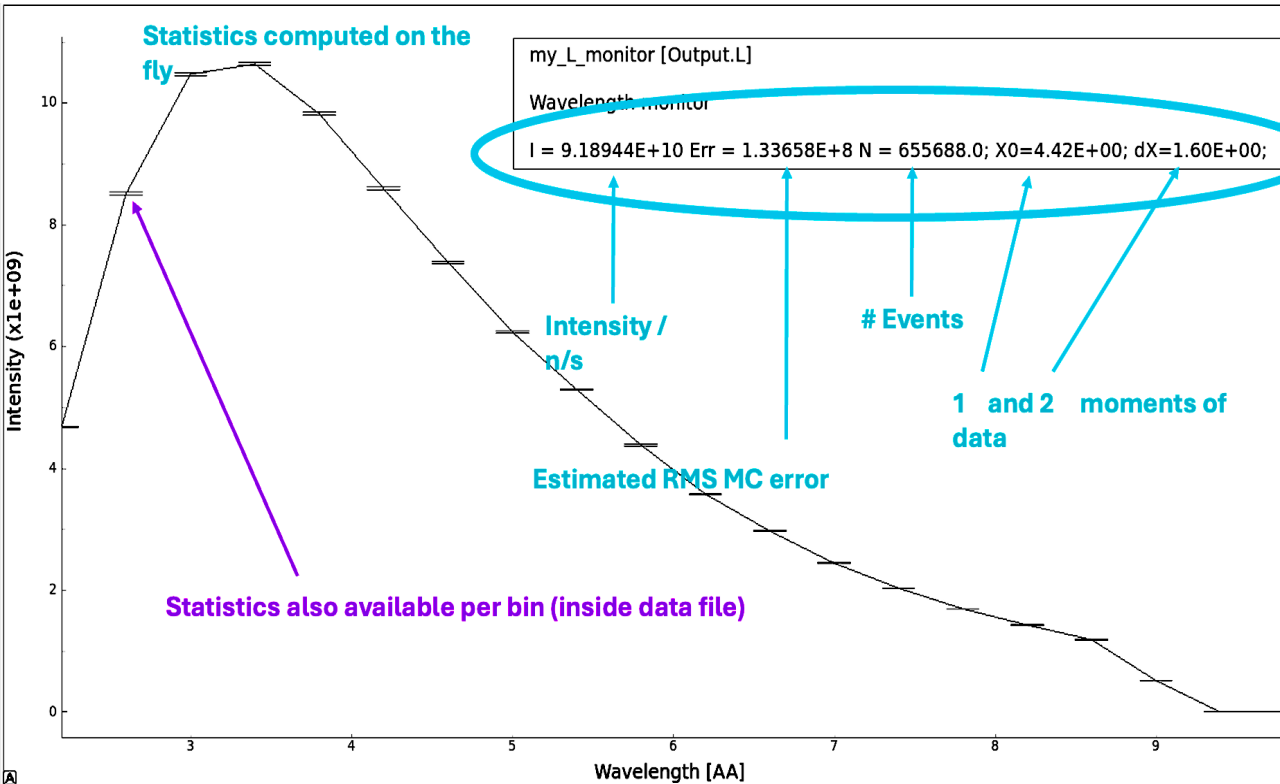
```
COMPONENT MyMon = Monitor_nD(xwidth=0.1, yheight=0.1, zdepth=0,  
    options="intensity per cm2 angle, limits=[-5 5], bins=10, with borders, file=mon1")
```

```
options = "banana, theta limits=[10,130], bins=120, y"
```

```
options = "user1, auto"    → with user1="age", username1="Age of the Captain [years]" — monitor just about  
anything.
```



1D and 2D example output (by default in Ascii)



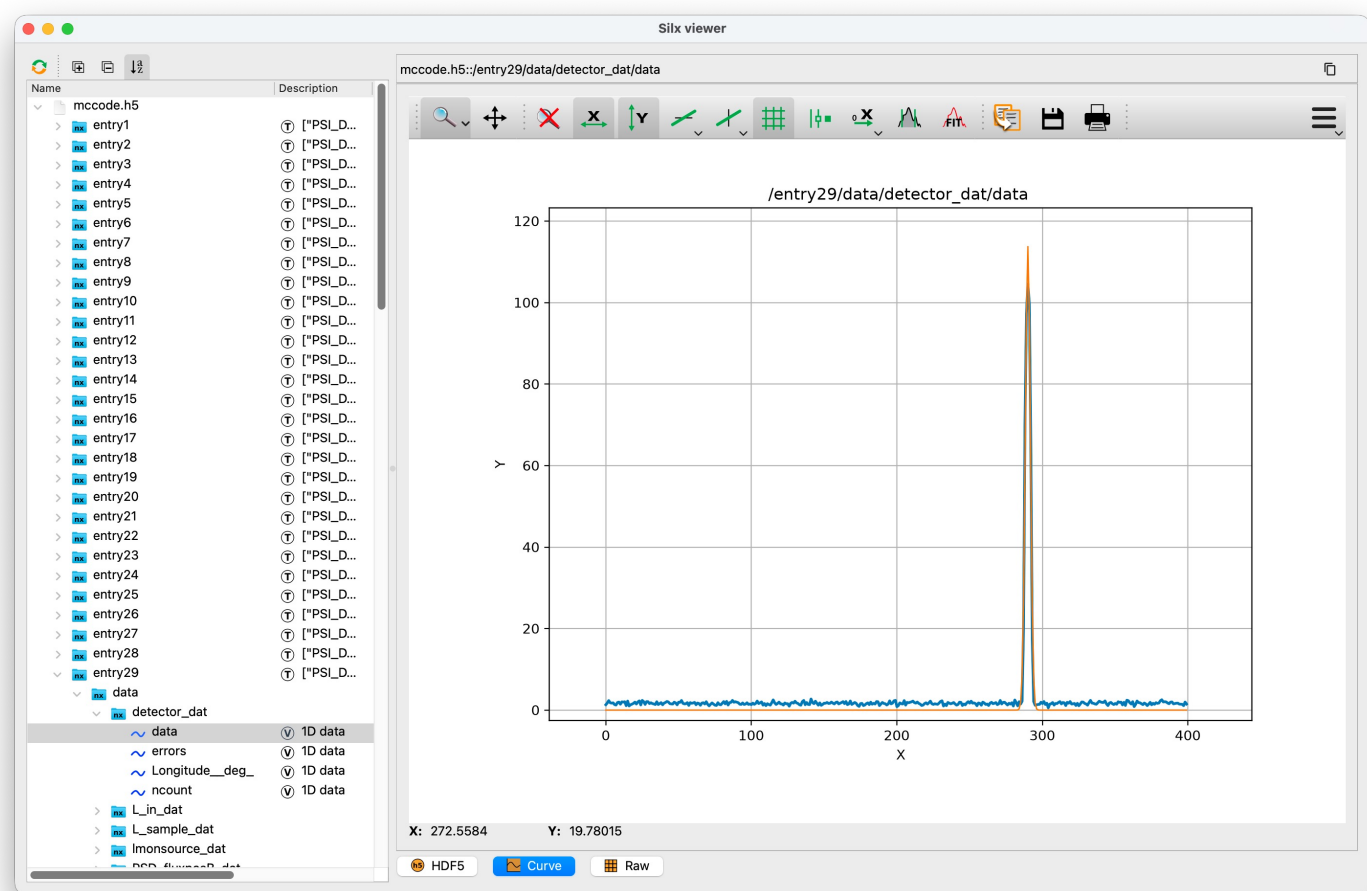
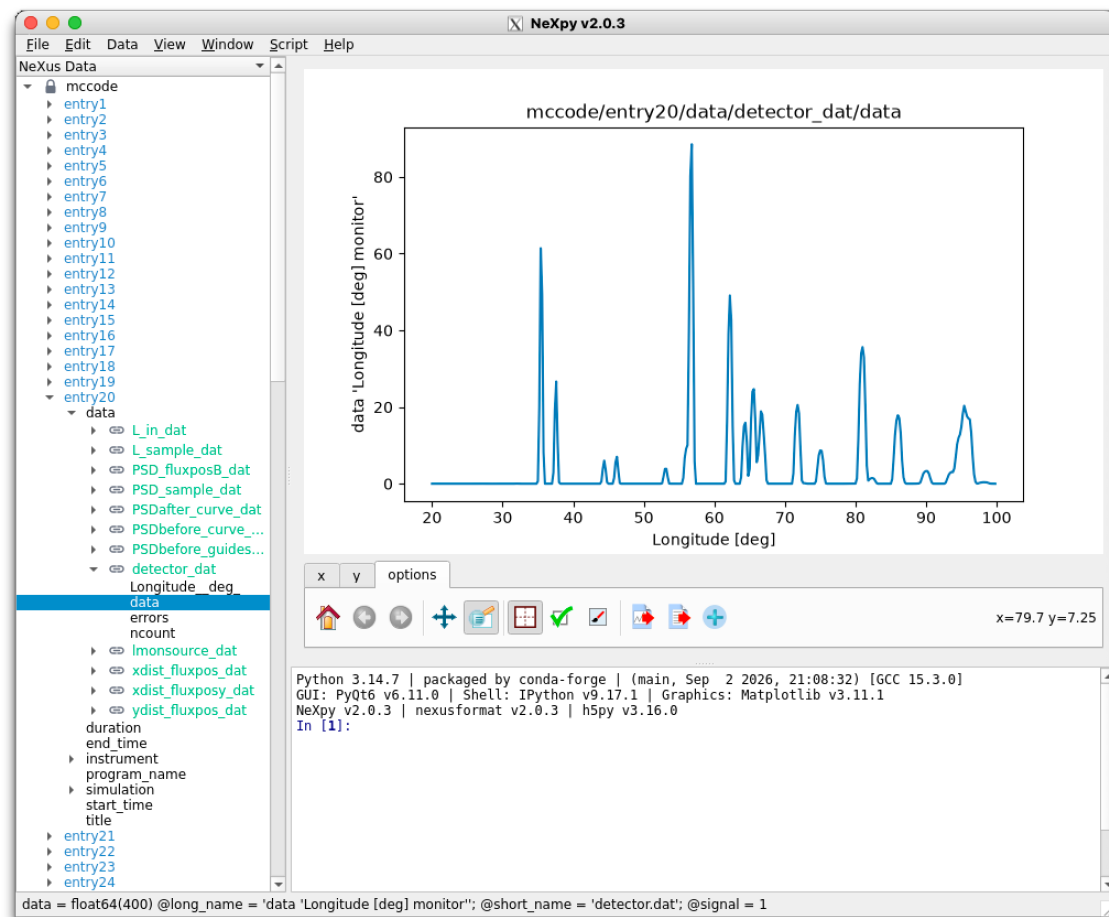
Plotting tools are [mcplot](#)(-pyqtgraph/-matplotlib/-html) for McStas and [mxplot](#)(-pyqtgraph/-matplotlib/-html) for McXtrace

There are further [mccoplot](#)/[mxcoplot](#) and [mcplotdiff](#)/[mxplotdiff](#) tools

When output is written in HDF5 / NeXus format we recommend the '[nexpy](#)' software

(always included when installing from conda-forge)

Lightweight HDF5/NeXus plotting, fits etc.



NeXpy





Sources differ; monitors mostly don't

What's shared

- A source's role: set the ray state from chosen distributions
- The solid-angle / ncount / weight formalism
- Simple analytic sources: Source_simple $\leftrightarrow$ Source_flat
- The monitor library, naming, and statistics engine
- Monitor_nD and its options syntax
- MCPL for coupling simulations together
- mcdoc / mxdoc as the doc-access pattern

What differs

- Source families: pulsed/reactor moderators vs. accelerator insertion devices
- Ray fields: velocity & spin vs. wave vector, phase & E-field
- Energy scale of the emitted spectrum: meV vs. keV
- A handful of probe-specific monitors (e.g. polarisation, neutron-only)
- Facility-specific source components (ISIS, SNS, ESS ... have no X-ray analogue)

Where to go deeper

McStas

`mcdoc / mcdoc -c`

mcstas.org/download/components

mcstas-users@mcstas.org

McXtrace

`mxdoc / mxdoc -c`

mcxtrace.org/download/components

mcxtrace-users@mcxtrace.org

Hands-on exercises on sources and monitors will be provided during the school session.

Peter Willendrup · pkwi@fysik.dtu.dk · DTU Physics